

Chapter

Sattva, Rajas, Tamas — Three Ropes and Their Balance



Introduction: Three Gunas, One Question

Sattva, rajas and tamas — we hear of these three gunas often. We tend to assume that sattva is good and tamas is bad. But what does the word "guna" really mean? And is sattva alone enough? In this short discourse, Acharya Upendra Ji teaches us to look at the three gunas in a different way — both as bondage, and as forces that life cannot do without.

"Guna" Means Rope

Acharya Ji begins with a simple question:

"Three gunas have been described, named sattva, rajas and tamas. What is the meaning of the word guna? An elementary Sanskrit student should know this."

He first gives the meaning we all know:

"Even in Marathi, what is the meaning of the word guna? Guna means quality, characteristics."

And then he turns to the original Sanskrit meaning:

"But look up the word guna in the dictionary — in Sanskrit — and the meaning of guna is rope, string. These are three ropes."

"Guna in the Gita — that guna is not quality. Quality is a secondary point. Mainly, it is a rope."

The fourteenth chapter of the Bhagavad Gita says exactly this — these three gunas, born of prakriti (nature), bind the

embodied soul to the body:

**sattvaṁ rajas tama iti guṇāḥ prakṛti-sambhavāḥ
nibadhnanti mahā-bāho dehe dehinam avyayam**

"Sattva, rajas and tamas — these gunas born of
nature, O mighty-armed one, bind the imperishable
soul within the body."
— Bhagavad Gita 14.5

A guna is not just a description of temperament; the gunas
are the ropes that bind us.

Even a Golden Chain Is Bondage

We readily accept that tamas and rajas bind us. But Acharya
Ji says clearly that sattva binds too:

"Three ropes — these can tie us up. This is maya. It has
been said that even sattva guna binds."

He gives a beautiful comparison for it:

"Even if you are bound with a chain of gold, that rope is of no benefit."

Whether the chain is of iron or of gold, the one who is bound stays bound.

Sattva guna is a golden chain: beautiful, precious — but bondage all the same.

How Does Sattva Bind?

Acharya Ji lists what belongs to sattva guna:

"Knowledge, happiness, dispassion, consciousness, discernment, intellect — sattva guna."

All of this is good. But even these can become a craving:

"But the craving for knowledge itself — 'let me read, let me read' — then your birth will be in a library. Bondage."

"Laziness. Again it seeks happiness. It seeks happiness — that is the problem."

The same holds for devotion and service:

"'Guru, Guru, Guru' — do bhakti, fine; do Guru seva — birth again. That will not bring liberation."

Knowledge, happiness, devotion — if attachment to these remains, it leads back to birth again. Liberation lies beyond the gunas.

All Three Gunas Are Needed

So should we avoid the gunas? No. Acharya Ji puts the other side just as firmly:

"Sattva alone is not right, rajas alone is not right, tamas alone is not right."

Each guna has its own work:

- **Rajas** — "If you have to act, then rajo guna."

- **Sattva** — "If you want to gain knowledge, then sattva guna."
- **Tamas** — "If you want to rest — tamas. If you have to destroy, to bring an end, then you need tamo guna."

And then he asks:

"So should we do only one thing all day long?"

The Right Guna at the Right Time

He explains this with an example from that very moment:

"Right now you are receiving knowledge — that will happen if sattva guna is there. If you fall asleep now, tamo guna has come at the wrong time."

"Sleep at night; if you stay awake now, that is good."

And even while receiving knowledge, the other gunas are still at work:

"But the action of it — our sitting is going on, karma is going on — that is the power of rajas. We require all three together."

Here is the real key:

"One only has to understand which one is predominant, and in which place."

The question is not "which guna is good?" — it is "which guna should be predominant at this moment?"

Three Gunas, Three Goddesses, Three Colours

Acharya Ji links the three gunas to three goddesses and their colours.

Mahasaraswati — sattva — white:

"That Mahasaraswati — she is of sattva guna. The colour of sattva is white, which is why Saraswati's dress is white."

Mahalakshmi — rajas — red:

He shows what rajo guna looks like through our everyday speech:

"Rajo guna — 'I am working with blood and sweat as one,' running about and running about, 'my blood boils' — action."

"The pressure has gone up, on the heart, blood pressure, rushing around — this is the power of rajas. The colour red belongs there — karma. So Lakshmi's colour is red."

Mahakali — tamas — black:

"Likewise Kali — black. The colour of tamas is black."

White for knowledge, red for action, black for rest and dissolution — the three goddesses are the three forces within us.

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1 Guna means rope.** In Sanskrit the main meaning of "guna" is rope; quality is a secondary meaning.
- 2 All three gunas bind — even sattva.** Sattva is a golden chain; even if it is gold, it is still a chain.
- 3 Craving even for good things becomes bondage.** Attachment to knowledge, happiness and devotion leads back to birth; it does not bring liberation.
- 4 No single guna alone is right.** Rajas for action, sattva for knowledge, tamas for rest and dissolution — all three are needed.
- 5 The right guna at the right time.** Falling asleep while receiving knowledge is tamas at the wrong time; sleep at night is the right one.
- 6 We require all three together.** Understanding which guna should be predominant where is the real art.
- 7 Three gunas, three goddesses.** Mahasaraswati (sattva, white), Mahalakshmi (rajas, red), Mahakali (tamas, black).